

# WITCHES OF FATE'S EDGE

## Cords, Curses, and the Quiet Work of Names

### What a Witch Is (and Isn't)

A witch is a **threshold worker**—one who listens to **Echo** (what has been), steadies the **Veil** (what is), and leans into **Flow** (what wishes to be). Witchcraft is not brute force; it is *fit*: finding where the world already wishes to move and giving it the precise nudge that sets it irrevocably in motion.

Hedge-witches there are in plenty: the Breath-Wardens of Aeler, the Hedge-Wrights of Viterra, the Bone-Singers of Ykrul. These are good folk, mostly. Their craft is folk-craft, learned by rote and grandmother's whisper. The true witch—the **threshold worker**—learns by the Cord, by the Thorn, and by the Silent Ninth. They are the ones who know that a doorway is not an absence but a presence, that a promise is a physical weight, and that to erase a name from memory is to rewrite the stone beneath it.

**The Gray Wanderer's Note:** *"The hedge is what keeps the wolves from the flock. I am the one who tends the hedge."*

## 1 I. First Principles

### 1.1 The Law of Named Existence

To name is to anchor. **True Names** fasten an Echo; forgetting frays it. Words spoken under witness reshape how a place remembers. Every curse, blessing, or bargain is a small act of creation through recognition. **Un-Naming** (suppression, forgetting) can weaken or banish.

### 1.2 The Concordant Layers

People, places, and vows exist as chords across Echo / Veil / Flow.

Witches feel dissonance within this chord and decide whether to *harmonize* (benediction), *redirect* (hex), or *lock in place* (binding). Wise law: do not sever, do not overrule, do not forget. Work with the existing harmony.

### 1.3 Threshold Mechanics

All workings start at **edges**—doorways, wakes, vows, last breaths, first light, crossroads, riverbanks. Magic is **boundary-law**: who may pass, what must stay, and what should never meet. Thresholds are points of maximum potential for change.

## 1.4 Element-Will

Elements are **wills**, not mere substances. A working "argues" with a chosen will; **Obligation** is the debt incurred when borrowing strength from a will larger than yours.

## 1.5 Story Weight

Stories have gravity. Meaning accrues; reality leans to fulfill it. When the table marks a complication (Story Beat), the world cashes what the scene has earned through narrative momentum.

## 1.6 The Silent Ninth

There is a missing step in the scale—acknowledged, never filled. The **Ninth** is absence with teeth: erasure, gaps, omissions, and the power of what is left unsaid. Manipulating the Ninth is potent and dangerous. Players never declare the Ninth; GMs may apply it only as consequence.

# 2 II. The Five Weavers

Where the Runekeeper swears an oath and the Invoker bargains at arm's length, the witch *incorporates*. Her power is intimate, cellular, corrupting in the old sense—not rotten, but *changed*. The patron's will flows through her like milk through a jug, leaving the vessel altered.

## 2.1 Morag the Hag — The Price Unspoken

Morag dwells at the crossroads where the road forks three ways. She is the grandmother who offers exactly what you need with a smile full of iron teeth. Her witches are deal-makers, oath-crafters, the ones who write contracts in milk on slate and know that every gift must be paid for, though the payment may not come due for a generation.

**Law of Hidden Costs** A witch of Morag can bind a promise with a red thread so fine you cannot see it until it tightens. She can ensure that a bridge stands for a century, but the cost is a child's laugh, taken in the night and kept in a jar. These witches are not evil; they are *precise*. They keep the records of consequence, and they never forget a weight.

**Signature Rite — The Speaking Knot (Standard, 8 XP)** Bind a promise with faerie knots that tighten when broken. Breach forces 2 sband marks the violator with a visible tell.

## 2.2 Inaea — Mercy and the Web

Inaea is the hearth-mother, the keeper of continuity, the spider at the center of the web. Where Morag demands payment, Inaea offers connection. Her witches bind families with invisible threads, ensure that oaths hold, and HEAL the cracks in the world's memory.

**The Thread That Binds** The witch of Inaea knows that the thread that comforts is the same that binds. She can lay a line of sanctuary across a threshold—no violence may cross it while the thread holds, but the thread remembers every blow it deflects. When it snaps, the weight comes due.

**Signature Rite — Hearth-Thread Knot (Low, 4 XP)** Bind yourself and one willing ally. Both gain +1 die to Aid each other this scene. If either takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 by suffering that same Harm instead.

## 2.3 Isoka — The Serpent's Shedding

Isoka is change made manifest, the venom that burns away the old self to make room for the new. Her witches are shapeshifters in the original sense: not beasts, but souls who have learned to molt their identities like snakeskin.

**The Shedding** A witch of Isoka can walk into a room as a stranger and leave as your sister, the shift so seamless that reality itself accepts the change. She can cure a disease by forcing the patient to *become* someone who never had it, though the former self is lost forever.

**Signature Rite — The Shedding (Standard, 8 XP)** +2 dice to resist a named Condition; declare a minor contingency retroactively. Mark 1 OBLIGATION 1.

## 2.4 Ikasha — She Who Sleeps in Silence

Ikasha is the patron of the threshold itself, of the space between what is said and what is meant, of the shadows that fall where no light cast them. Her witches move unseen, not by bending light but by occupying the *absence*—the Ninth space, the gap between numbers, the forgotten step on the stair.

**The Unspoken** To call upon Ikasha is to court erasure. Her witches can remove a name from a record, from a memory, from history itself, leaving only a gap that aches like a missing tooth.

**Signature Rite — Touch the Umbral Veil (Low, 4 XP)** Start **Controlled** on one Stealth roll. **Push It:** The effect lasts the full scene; mark +1 Shadow.

## 2.5 The Thorns of Malachai — The Gift That Bites

Malachai is the Chained Angel, the Cruel Messenger, the one who answers when the desperate call. Her witches do not serve her so much as *survive* her. They are the cursed, the addicted, the broken who learned to weaponize their own fractures.

**The Leashed Gift** Every gift remembers how to bite. A Thorn can grant a desperate ally +2 dice on a crucial roll—but the ally will owe a favor to something that collects at midnight. She can curse an enemy with a luck so foul that their own shadow trips them—but the curse will spread to anyone who stands too close.

**The Thorn's Bargain:** A witch of Malachai does not ask "What will this cost?" She asks "Who will pay the interest?"

**Signature Rite — The Leashed Gift (Standard, 7 XP)**

Grant a target +2 dice on their next roll. They gain a DEBT [4]. When it fills, Malachai collects: a memory, a name, or a service. The witch cannot refuse the collection—only redirect it to another target.

# 3 III. The Two Speeds of Witchcraft

The **Long Road** is ritual, threshold, price, and consequence: curses woven, bargains struck, the world's memory rewritten. It takes Significant Time (hours, days, a moon phase).

The **Short Road** is instinct, residue, and flicker of attention: a suddenly turned tide, a bell rung at the right moment, a thread plucked. It takes Some Time (a few heartbeats, a single action).

### 3.1 Hedge Gifts

A Hedge Gift is not a spell. It is the world tilting slightly in the witch's favor because she has paid attention to the right thresholds. Hedge Gifts require no dice roll; they simply work within their limited scope.

### 3.2 Quick Workings

A Quick Working is a single-action roll that relies on the witch's knowledge of thresholds, elements, and will. Its effects are limited, subtle, and always carry the risk of debt.

#### Procedure

1. Name the Threshold (door, tide line, wound, vow, breath)
2. Choose a Layer (Echo, Veil, or Flow) and a single Tag
3. GM sets Position (Controlled if you have time, Desperate if threatened)
4. Roll Attribute + Skill (typically Wits + Lore, Spirit + Insight, or Presence + Sway)
5. Apply Outcome Matrix

#### Example Effects

- A door sticks shut (or opens)
- A candle gutters (brief darkness)
- A rope knot tightens (or loosens)
- A pursuer's footing slips (1 Fatigue)
- A whispered name is heard (or forgotten)

### 3.3 Full Rituals

When a witch has Significant Time (at least an hour), she may perform a Full Ritual using the five-step Threshold Working:

1. **Identify the Threshold:** Name the edge, learn its disposition
2. **Choose a Witness:** A person, spirit, or Hollowed who watches
3. **Name the Will:** What change you intend
4. **Set the Price:** Memory, name, lock of hair, promise, blood
5. **Make the Exchange:** Roll (Spirit + Lore typically), resolve, pay the price on success or partial

Full Rituals can produce permanent or long-lasting effects: curses, blessings, marks, bindings, and unravellings.

## 4 IV. The Three Prices

Every working demands a price. Choose **one** unless a rite specifies otherwise.

| Layer       | Domain                                               | Risk                                    |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| <b>Echo</b> | Accumulated memory and intention                     | Recursion (past actions repeat)         |
| <b>Veil</b> | Present state, boundary between potential and actual | Hairline cracks (subtle reality breaks) |
| <b>Flow</b> | Direction of change, will of elements                | Overshoot (change goes too far)         |

| Gift             | Effect                                                                               | Limit            |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Steady Hand      | Remove 1 Fatigue from yourself or a touched ally                                     | Once per scene   |
| Salt Line        | Pour a line of salt; spirits test Spirit+Resolve DV 3 to cross                       | Once per scene   |
| Hearth-Sense     | Ask the GM one yes/no question about a threshold, boundary, or debt                  | Once per scene   |
| The Unlit Candle | Extinguish a light source; create dim light or darkness in Near                      | Once per session |
| Knot of Favor    | Tie a knot; you and allies gain +1 die to one type of roll for the scene             | Once per scene   |
| Warm Hand        | Touch someone; their next physical action gains +1 die (comfort) or -1 die (warning) | Once per scene   |

| Roll Result                                | Effect                                      | Cost                                 |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Clean Success ( $S \geq DV$ , $SB = 0$ )   | Effect manifests cleanly                    | No cost                              |
| Success with SB ( $S \geq DV$ , $SB > 0$ ) | Effect works; GM spends SB for complication | Mark 1 Fatigue or accept a Condition |
| Partial ( $0 < S < DV$ )                   | Effect works partially or briefly           | Gain 1 Boon; threshold remembers you |
| Miss ( $S = 0$ )                           | Effect fails                                | Gain 2 Boons; start PROMISE [4]      |

| Ritual            | Effect                                   | DV   | Price                                    |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------|------|------------------------------------------|
| Unravel the Wound | Restore 1 level of Harm                  | 3-5+ | Lock of hair, memory, a tear in a vial   |
| Hallow Threshold  | Permanently ward a door, well, or bridge | 4-6  | Offering (bread, salt, coin, promise)    |
| Unbind the Anchor | Permanently release a spirit             | 4-6  | Fulfill the spirit's unfinished business |

| Price           | What It Is                                            | Recovery                                                      |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Shadow</b>   | Spiritual residue; GM gains 1 SB; may introduce tells | Clears when the tell manifests or at session end              |
| <b>Shame</b>    | Internal consequence; gain a Condition                | Remove by acting against the compulsion or through confession |
| <b>Identity</b> | Loss of self; mark 1 Identity Strain                  | Requires downtime or a Full Ritual                            |

## 4.1 Push It

Before rolling or after a Partial, you may Push to enhance the working. Choose one:

- Mark **+1 Shadow** and gain **+1 die**
- Mark **+1 Shame** and gain **+1 Effect**
- Mark **+1 Identity Strain** and reduce DV by 1 (minimum 2)

## 4.2 Identity Strain Track

Identity Strain tracks cumulative erosion from self-touching magic.

Identity Strain cannot be healed by ordinary rest. It requires:

- A Full Ritual of restoration (DV 5, requires a witness and a personal offering)
- A significant downtime scene (confession, remembrance, or reclaiming a lost name)
- Accepting a permanent change (converting Strain into a Scar or Condition)

## 5 V. Promise Timers

Many workings create obligations. Represent these with a PROMISE [4] or PROMISE [6].

- Mark the timer when the promise is ignored, deferred, or disrespected
- When filled, the price comes due—socially, spiritually, or narratively

Examples: sharing grief, tending a grave, protecting a hearth, reconciling rivals.

## 6 VI. Threshold Magic (Social & Interpersonal)

Threshold magic is communal, relational, and liminal. It operates where one thing becomes another: doorways, crossings, hearth edges, birthbeds, gravesides, and moments between choices.

### 6.1 Core Laws

**Law of Hospitality** You cannot take what you will not feed. Every working requires an offering: comfort, labor, memory, or promise.

**Law of Reciprocity** Binding another binds yourself to their outcome. All curses create a *Bond Condition* between caster and target.

**Law of Witness** Unseen workings fray. Present witness grants Position +1; casting without witness incurs +1 DV or *Lone Witch Condition* (GM choice).

### 6.2 Household Disposition

Communities and dwellings possess temperament. When entering a new settlement or threshold site, choose or roll:

**Hungry:** demands offerings; first working costs +1 Fatigue

**Grieving:** magic requires memory or loss narrative

**Fearful:** first rite is Desperate Position

**Watching:** +1 Effect if the house is fed or soothed

**Young:** chaotic outcomes on partials

**Old:** weak boons but harsh backlash

Household temperament can change through care, ritual, or story.

## 7 VII. The Craft of the Hedge (Talent)

Talent: Craft of the Hedge

**Cost:** 4 XP

**Requirements:** Lore 1+ or Survival 1+; a witch mark (tattoo, scar, or birthmark)

You have learned the small magics of thresholds and edges. You gain:

- Two Hedge Gifts of your choice
- The ability to perform Quick Workings
- Once per session, when you fail a Quick Working roll, you may convert the Miss into a Partial Success by marking 1 Fatigue

You may learn additional Hedge Gifts for 2 XP each.

Talent: Hedge Gift of the Patron (Optional)

**Cost:** 6 XP

**Requirements:** Craft of the Hedge, Bond to a Patron

Once per session, when you would use a Hedge Gift, you may instead invoke your Patron's Imbuement. Gain +1 die to all actions tied to your Patron's domain for the scene, but mark +1 Obligation immediately. No action required.

## 8 VIII. Curses as Architecture (GM Tool)

A witch does not curse with a word and a gesture. She *edits* the memory of the world, inserting a rule into the operating system of reality.

*"Until a bell is rung in your true name, lamps forget to light for you."*

### Anatomy of a Curse

- **The Rule:** What changes (Veil-edit, bound to a Named anchor)
- **The Timer:** RECURSION [6] — ticks when the victim reinforces the story (hiding, refusing witness, denying the curse)
- **The Counter:** What undoes it (the bell, the name, the threshold)
- **The SB Menu:** Complications the GM can spend SB on (minor echoes, warped thresholds, layer-slips, Ninth propagation)

## 9 IX. Quick Reference

### Keeper's Quick Questions

- Which layer am I touching—Echo, Veil, or Flow?
- What threshold frames the scene (door, ford, oath, mask, ledger, ferry)?
- Which Name anchors—and which must be loosened?
- Where does the Ninth already bite—and who benefits if it closes?

**Remember.** Spend complications (Story Beats) like fate tugging the scene toward the story with the most weight—then let good witness (and player action) change which story that is. In this world, belief, craft, and consequence braid into law; witchcraft is the art of tying knots that hold without choking.

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| Segments | Effect                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1-3      | No mechanical effect; GM may offer a Devil's Bargain tied to identity                                                                                                                                                                        |
| 4        | <b>Threshold reached.</b> At end of scene, roll Spirit + Resolve vs DV 4. On success, clear 1 Strain. On failure, the GM chooses: a memory blurs, a bond becomes conditional, a name becomes <i>buried</i> , or an echo-self becomes active. |

| What                                                                                          | When                     | Roll                        | Price                           |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Hedge Gift                                                                                    | Once per scene/session   | No roll                     | None (limited scope)            |
| Quick Working                                                                                 | Single action            | Attribute + Skill vs DV 2-4 | Shadow, Shame, or Identity      |
| Full Ritual                                                                                   | Significant Time (hours) | Spirit + Lore vs DV 3-6     | Memory, offering, or service    |
| Curse                                                                                         | Scene or longer          | GM sets DV                  | Identity (mandatory for Thorns) |
| <b>Identity Strain Track:</b> [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ] — at 4, test Spirit+Resolve or lose something.  |                          |                             |                                 |
| <b>Promise Timer:</b> [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ] / [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ] [ ] — when full, price comes due. |                          |                             |                                 |